In India, the term ‘Rama–Lakshmana’ is popularly used as an expression for describing closeness between siblings. But transpose this to the domain of global politics and reflect on its implications. The fact is that every Rama needs a Lakshmana, someone trustworthy and vigilant who will share both successes and sorrows. At crucial moments, he provided courage, counselled composure and steadied his principal. When the demon Viradh kidnapped Sita in Dandakaranya forest, it was Lakshmana who exhorted a shaken Rama to take swift counter-action. When Rama vented his frustration after Ravana’s more successful abduction, it was again his brother who narrated how others dealt with misfortune through patience and fortitude. Thereafter, as Rama lost his cool with the seagod Varuna, who would not allow him to cross into Lanka, it was Lakshmana who persuaded him not to intimidate the god more than necessary. How to build close and reliable partnerships is the perennial task of diplomacy.

Every nation, however large or powerful, needs such sources of support. They may have a situational salience but the fact is that once established, such relationships have multiple ways of making themselves valuable. This is obviously a far cry from the normally transactional nature of international relations. It requires generosity, care, consideration and, sometimes, even affection. There is even some place for sentiment in world affairs, illustrated by that adage of blood being thicker than water. The solidarity of shared experiences is no weak bond either. India opened its heart through Vaccine Maitri, it was a gesture that will stand it in good stead for a long time. Indeed, as it rises up the global hierarchy of power, the requirement for reliable friends will grow, not lessen. The broader the footprint and greater the interests, the more is the importance of Lakshmanas.

The unstinted devotion of another player may be a relative rarity in real life, but significant enterprises in global history generally require assembling a larger coalition of support. This is particularly so when the nature and outcome of endeavours are open-ended. As activities are taking place far away from one’s zone of familiarity, the value of associates goes up commensurately. This is further enhanced if they bring a particular skill or contribution to the collective effort. When confronting a larger or unusual opponent, the need for allies and well-wishers is still more keenly felt. We have seen this even in modern history, whether we think back to the World Wars, the Gulf War, Afghanistan or even ongoing situations. In the case of Rama, he was utterly at a loss to even guess how and where his abducted wife could have been taken. He finally tracked her through the multiple contributions of well-wishers and allies of various kinds. It does not always take a combat situation for this to be realized. In the competitive world of international politics, each friend who stands up in a difficult situation is one to be prized.

The coalition of *vanaras* that set out in every direction to gather intelligence is an equally powerful example of such sentiment. It was the force under Prince Angada, which had gone south, that learnt of Sita being in the gardens of Lanka. Without the army of monkeys, the bears and the eagles, Rama perhaps could not have got his bearings right. The need to be situationally aware when making important decisions is evident.

Often, some challenges may be beyond purely national capabilities and the contribution that well-wishers can make could be invaluable. Sampati’s extraordinary sight is an analogy for accessing vital information about competitors and adversaries. And when the time came to cross the oceans, it was Nala, the bridge-building son of Vishwakarma, who provided the technology solution. Varuna went against his very nature in promising not to wash over the bridge that Nala built. This was the result of coercion by Rama, who in his anger, had threatened to dry up the seas if he was not allowed to cross.

Making friends and influencing people does involve a range of motivating factors, from incentives and flattery to assistance and threats. For most nations, this is an exceptionally patient and arduous task and may not be as easy as it seems. Generally speaking, it requires an astute identification of its components and accommodation among competing interests. On exceptional occasions, there could even be difficult choices made for larger good. At the heart of one such case is the most debated action of Lord Rama in the epic. In an ongoing battle between the two sibling